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Master Thesis

Integration of model-driven development approaches into the domain of mobile applications

Classification of an interpreter implementation for mobile applications

Analysis of a model interpreter on the basis of an existing implementation

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von

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Erklärung der Selbstständigkeit

Hiermit versichere ich, die vorliegende Arbeit selbstständig verfasst und keine anderen als die angegebenen Quellen und Hilfsmittel benutzt sowie die Zitate deutlich kenntlich gemacht zu haben.

Gießen, den March 5, 2019 Samuel Schepp

This thesis describes configuration-based mobile applications and their infrastructure. In addition, a possible way of implementing a configuration system is discussed. Finally, the implementation is compared to the approach of established literature by classifying the model and interpreter.

Furthermore, there is an evaluation of the use case of interpreting and generated apps.

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1 Introduction

Mobile application and digital media usage is still on the rising[Per]. Mobile applications are one of many possible ways to interact with customers and consumers. A web appearance on social media or a dedicated web page can also fulfill these needs. The way, the user interacts with a web page is more shallow, because of lower expectations. A user needs to log in most of the time.

A mobile application can enable user specific features without logging in, because the user can be identified with an identification token, that is generated, while the user installs the app. It is possible to activate special features like geofencing, push notifications or local data storage, that is synchronized with the platform cloud services (e.g. Apple iCloud or Google Drive).

A mobile app is integrated more deeply into the device, than a web app. However, web browser already support a lot of the features by now, that originally were only available to native apps. The current development indicates, that the differences will be further eliminated by the browser vendors.

1.1 Problem definition

Mobile applications have significant disadvantages, that push the development of web apps forward. Changes have to be approved by the phone vendors, in order to be able to release updates to the app. This causes development delays and reduces the ability to react to events or customer requirement changes.

All apps have to be kept in good condition, which creates more work, the more apps there need to be maintained. New operating system features have to be implemented in all of the apps, which can cause inconsistencies. All apps have to be tested in detail, to make sure that all apps implement the required change correctly. Platform changes can only be dealt with one by one. Developers need deep system knowledge to develop the apps. Every change has to go through one of each platform experts, so development is expensive.

An example for a change, that all apps should implement is the display notch. It causes the screen to extend to the edge of the display. However some of the screen is cut out to make room for sensors and the camera.

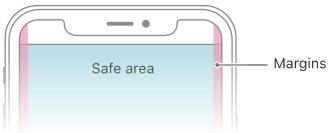

Figure 1.1: Display notch with safe area, Apple iPhone X

The notch is integrated to the default interface framework, so that developers can react accordingly and use the provided margins. This change requires all apps to implement a correct way to handle that. Developers have to go though every screen and correct the view.

1.2 Motivation

To be able to deliver the full mobile application experience, the app has to be native. This will change, when all of the phone's hardware interface is exposed to the web browser and user interface performance is better. But for now, the only way to use these features and be good on battery life and data usage is by providing a native app, that is written in the native language and uses features, directly provided by the phone vendors.

Web app wrapper like "ionic" are able to use these features and provide their own interface to the web app. In this way, a web app can in fact use restricted components like push notifications and beacons.

With this approach, every new app still has to be developed and old ones have to be maintained individually. In addition, it involves the dependence on third party framework vendors. Building apps with ionic creates a massive list of dependencies: ionic, angular, npm and nodejs. Native apps have the ability to reduce reliance, by only using native libraries, which are very comprehensive by default.

To be able to create many apps with little effort, a model driven approach can be considered. A well abstracted model can have the ability to be easy to understand by users and the platforms can bring their respected implementation in, so any app looks and feels native. A service can deliver pre-rendered sub-models, so that complex client workload can be moved to the server.

Existing apps are easy to maintain, because there is only one code base per platform. One bug fix applies to all apps. Also, it is easy for anyone to change small things like a

label, a background color or the sorting of a list. The goal is, to be able to configure new apps in one day, together with the customer.

1.3 Distinction

This thesis will not describe the development experience nor the initial expense of the project. Neither will this thesis evaluate financial aspects and at which point, the project was or is worth the development costs. The domain examination will be narrowed down to the two main ones, mobile phones and digital signage.

The thesis aims to answer the question:

> How can a code interpreter be integrated in the domain of mobile applications?

1.4 Structure

The thesis will give some information on the background of the interpreter. The company Fabrik19 GmbH, which is actively developing and maintaining an implementation, will be described and characterized. After that, the general concept of model driven development, code generators and interpreters are examined and presented.

The main content will then be about the concrete implementation, by describing the most significant design choices, overall infrastructure and usage examples. The focus will be on the two main platforms 'iOS' and 'Android'. The web and '.Net' clients are not considered, because they are not targeted for mobile devices and only support a subset of the model.

In the final chapter, the concept is applied to the implementation, to see how it fits the theoretical model of interpreters. Differences are worked out and discussed.

2 Background

The system, that is discussed here, is a model interpreter that is designed to run mobile applications on iOS and Android. The system, which includes the interpreters and the backends are called mos[1]. It is in active development and poweres over 50 apps that all are available in the Apple AppStore and Google PlayStore. The app categories range from retail to event to city marketing apps[2].

2.1 Fabrik19

The creator of the system is Fabrik 19 GmbH. The company is based in Gießen, Hesse, Germany and was founded 20XX by Mark Pralle and Sven Herchenhein. At the moment, the company has bout 25 employees. Besides of apps, there are also other projects and solutions, like consulting and webhosting.

2.1.1 Markets

Fabrik19 does not deliver apps directly to customers, but is partner of retail corporations and city marketing agencies. The current flagship is the Gießen App, which was developed in cooperation with DISTAMA GmbH. The app was downloaded 34,000 times and has 20 distinct and active users per day.

Besides mobile apps, digital signage is another important market. The companion to the Gießen App is a stele that contains a large touchscreen and runs an app that is optimized for big touchscreens. It is located on the main pedestrian shopping street in Gießen and provides respective informations on the stores and points of interests[3]. Other stele systems are also active in Globus hardware stores and Globus grocery stores.

1 Mobility Suite
2 `https://fabrik19.de/technologie/`
3 `https://distama.de/bid-seltersweg/`

2.2 Mobility Suite

The main development focus lays on the app interpreter platform ”mos”. It supports the two major platforms iOS and Android, but there is also a lightweight version available in .Net, which is running on the steles as a Windows app. A web client is also actively in development, which aims to replace the .Net version.

A configuration are multiple JSON files, that represent the app meta information, its layout and its behavior. The files are called node. There is one root node, whose url is baked into the app while compiling. This root node defines the first screen of the app. All the other screens can be defined in other nodes. When displaying another node, the new node is loaded from cache or network and its new view is pushed on the view stack, which is done by the interpreter. On the particular platforms, this action will look different and will use the platforms native animations. Web apps like Ionic have their own push animations which makes them feel foreign. The previous node can pass data, like the ID of the item that should be displayed.

The goal is, to be able to create a new app in one day, by meeting with the customer and configuring the app together. The syntax of the configuration is designed to abstract all of an apps standard behavior. Because of a custom layout system, that can be described with constraints and will layout automatically, it is not possible to recognize that it is only a configured app, instead of a custom native one.

The apps have sophisticated caching and optimization mechanisms, which makes it possible to use them completely offline, without any additional configuration effort. The configuration, images and data are cached heavily, which makes the apps very fast. But because of the dynamic design of the configuration syntax, it is possible to clear the caches and force new versions. The cache first policy of the interpreter makes sure, that contents are always available and loads changes in the background.

Besides of displaying data, the client is highly intractable and can perform various custom tasks on the device, like uploading local data, saving data to the devices user settings and providing push, beacon and location infrastructure.

This data can be used in describing the layout by defining layer conditions, which makes the app behave accordingly.

2.2.1 Use cases

The main use cases are marketing and customer interaction. The concept is data source driven and enables configuration of any data source. Because of a template engine, data can be arranged for display in an intuitive way.

Since the configuration can be changed on the fly and without the need of providing an update via app store, the contents can be adjusted to fit current events like holidays or promotions. Especially for digital signage it is important to be able to change the contents without any updates.

2.2.2 Interoperability

The app can be loaded with data via common REST services, that deliver JSON data. The app now uses HTTP mechanisms and a custom delta system to only load new data. The mos backend system also has a custom data proxy, which can load any data and provide it for the apps. This way, it is possible to use any data source and still be able to change the templates and layouts without updates.

It is possible to integrate an app in a Wordpress instance, a chat service like Mattermost or an secured API that uses authentication methods like client certificates, auth headers or JSON web tokens.

By default any network communication is secured with an app specific client certificate. Other authentication methods have to be configured.

3 Concept

3.1 Models

3.1.1 General models specification

3.1.2 Descriptive Models

3.1.3 Prescriptive Models

3.2 Model driven development

3.2.1 Code generators

3.2.2 Code interpreters

3.3 Implementation goals

Same day delivery

easy configuration

simple datasources

common app tasks simplified

content driven (wordpress, social media)

reactive form elements

3.3.1 Trade offs

boundary conditions

limits to development of app contents (app is out, but the customer needs more functionality, which is not possible: incomprehensible reasons for limits.)

4 Implementation

lorem ipsum

4.1 Language

4.2 Components

4.2.1 Nodes

4.2.2 Layouts

4.2.3 Database

4.2.4 Actions

4.2.5 Data proxy

4.3 Infrastructure

4.3.1 Control center

4.3.2 Resource server

4.3.3 Image cruncher

5 Evaluation

lorem ispum

5.1 Analysis

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5.1.1 Benefits

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5.1.2 Disadvantages

lorem ispum

5.2 Classification

5.2.1 Approach

5.2.2 Model

5.3 Conclusion

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[Per] Perkins, Kleiner: Internet Trends Report 2018, URL https://www.kleinerperkins.com/perspectives/internet-trends-report-2018/

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